

13 payment plan, a health FSA, or an HRA, but only if the coverage offered does not consist solely of excepted benefits. See 26 C.F.R. §1.36B-2(c)(3)(vii). If an employee enrolls in any employer-sponsored minimum essential coverage, the employee is ineligible for individual coverage subsidized by the Code § 36B premium tax credit.

Question 12: Section 125(f)(3) of the Code, effective for taxable years beginning after December 31, 2013, provides that the term "qualified benefit" does not include any QHP (as defined in ACA § 1301(a)) offered through an Exchange.¹¹ This prohibits an employer from providing a QHP offered through an Exchange as a benefit under the employer's Code § 125 plan. Some states have already established Exchanges and employers in those states may have Code § 125 plan provisions that allow employees to enroll in health coverage through the Exchange as a benefit under a Code § 125 plan. If the employer's Code § 125 plan operates on a plan year other than a calendar year, may the employer continue to provide the Exchange coverage through a Code § 125 plan after December 31, 2013? Answer 12: For Code § 125 plans that as of September 13, 2013 operate on a plan year other than a calendar year, the restriction under Code § 125(f)(3) will not apply before the first plan year of the Code § 125 plan that begins after December 31, 2013. Thus, for the remainder of a plan year beginning in 2013, a QHP provided through an Exchange as a benefit under a Code § 125 plan will not result in all benefits provided under the Code § 125 plan being taxable. However, individuals may not claim a Code § 36B premium tax credit for any month in which the individual was covered by a QHP provided through an Exchange as a benefit under a Code § 125 plan.

IV. APPLICABILITY DATE AND RELIANCE PERIOD This Technical Release applies for plan years beginning on and after January 1, 2014, but the guidance provided in this Technical Release may be applied for all prior periods. If legislative action by any State, local, or Indian tribal government entity is necessary to modify the terms of a pre-existing HRA, a health FSA that does not qualify as excepted benefits, an employer payment plan, or other similar arrangement, sponsored by any State, local, or Indian tribal government entity, as an employer, to avoid a failure to comply with the market reforms (including action to terminate such arrangement) and such action may only be taken by a State, local, or Indian tribal government entity legislative body, the applicability date of the portions of this Technical Release under which such arrangement would otherwise fail to comply with the market reforms is extended to the later of (1) January 1, 2014, or (2) the first day of the first plan year following the first close of a regular legislative session of the applicable legislative body after September 13, 2013.

¹¹ This rule does not apply with respect to any employee if the employee's employer is a qualified employer (as defined in ACA § 1312(f)(2)) offering the employee the opportunity to enroll through an Exchange in a qualified health plan in a group market. See Code § 125(f)(3)(B).